

Product Teardown: Corporate Travel Management Platform

1. Problem Statement

In mid-to-large enterprises, corporate travel workflows are inefficient because approvals, policy enforcement, and payments are handled as disconnected, manual steps. While booking flights or hotels is relatively easy, the surrounding workflow introduces delays, rework, and uncertainty for employees, managers, and finance teams.

These inefficiencies result in:

- Lost employee productivity
- Higher travel costs due to delays and rebooking
- Increased operational overhead for managers and finance teams
- Reduced trust in internal travel systems

The core issue is workflow orchestration, not the availability of booking options.

2. User Personas

Primary Persona: Employee / Traveler

Profile

- Corporate employee with frequent work travel
- Time-constrained and outcome-driven

Goals

- Book travel quickly
- Get approvals without follow-ups
- Avoid rebooking and finance-related issues

Pain Points

- Approval uncertainty
- Confusion around policy compliance
- Payment failures and invoice follow-ups

Secondary Persona: Manager / Approver

Profile

- People manager or budget owner
- Approvals are interruptive, not core work

Goals

- Make fast, confident approval decisions

Pain Points

- Too many ad-hoc approval requests
- Lack of fare, policy, and context at decision time

Tertiary Persona: Finance / Admin

Profile

- Finance or operations team responsible for audits and reporting

Goals

- Ensure compliance and accurate reporting

Pain Points

- Manual invoice reconciliation
- Fragmented and untrustworthy data

3. Persona Prioritisation

The Employee / Traveler is prioritised as the primary persona because:

- They initiate every travel workflow
- They experience the highest uncertainty and rework
- Their friction cascades into manager delays and finance overhead

Improving the employee experience reduces downstream operational burden across the organization.

4. Current User Journey (Pre-Platform)

1. Employee searches flights and hotels across multiple consumer tools
2. Manually compares prices and availability
3. Shares shortlisted options via email or messaging apps
4. Waits for manager approval with no visibility or SLA
5. Faces rejection due to policy issues and must rebook
6. Attempts payment (sometimes fails or requires retries)
7. Manually submits invoices to finance
8. Responds to follow-up questions days or weeks later

Key Friction Areas

- Waiting without clarity
- Rework after rejection
- Payment and invoicing issues
- No single source of truth

5. Core Pain Points

Pain Point 1: Approval Uncertainty

Employees lack visibility into approval status, timelines, and decision criteria. Even when managers respond promptly, the absence of a structured workflow creates stress, follow-ups, and delays. This uncertainty often leads to missed booking windows and higher costs.

This is a system design problem, not a people problem.

Pain Point 2: Late Policy Enforcement Creates Rework

Policy compliance is typically checked **after** booking or option selection. Corporate travel policies are complex, contextual, and subject to change, making them difficult to remember even for experienced employees.

As a result, reasonable but non-compliant choices are rejected late, forcing employees to redo the same work and repeat approval cycles.

Pain Point 3: Finance Chaos After Booking

Booking, approval, payment, and invoicing data live in separate systems. When invoices reach finance, they often lack reliable approval and policy context, requiring manual verification. This increases processing time, audit risk, and employee follow-ups.

The core issue is data integrity, not visibility alone.

6. Pain Point Prioritisation

Pain points were prioritised based on **frequency of occurrence** and **downstream impact**.

Priority Order

1. **Approval Uncertainty (Highest Priority)**
 - Occurs on every trip
 - Blocks all downstream actions
 - Drives waiting, follow-ups, and booking delays
2. **Late Policy Enforcement (High Priority)**
 - Creates direct rework
 - Multiplies effort across employees and managers
3. **Finance Reconciliation Overhead (Secondary Priority)**
 - Impacts fewer users directly
 - Occurs after travel completion

Rationale:

Problems that block progress were prioritised over problems that create cleanup work.

7. Wireframes / UX Flow

Figma - <https://www.figma.com/proto/33FRsrlybFALc0xpOMLnUB/Travel-Agent-Version1.0?node-id=50-1858&t=VxDkVjDhNH6M8d2K-0&scaling=min-zoom&content-scaling=fixed&page-id=0%3A1&starting-point-node-id=48%3A1098&show-proto-sidebar=1>

- Search flow optimized to require minimum input fields
- Cab booking flow focused on transparency → map first, fare second
- Search flow optimized to require **minimum input fields**
- Approval screen simplified to **Approve / Reject / Request Info**
- Dashboard follows **cards** → **charts** → **table** hierarchy
- Navigation grouped as: *Travel, Approvals, Payments, Dashboard*

8. Solution Strategy

The platform is designed around four principles:

- Move decisions earlier in the journey
- Automate default, low-risk paths
- Route exceptions with clear context
- Tightly couple approval, payment, and invoicing

The goal is to prevent issues rather than fix them later.

9. Solutions

Solution 1: Rule-Based Approval Workflow

- Approval requests are generated directly within the booking flow
- Managers receive contextual, one-click approval requests
- Low-risk, within-policy bookings are auto-approved

Addresses:

Approval uncertainty by making approvals visible, predictable, and fast.

Solution 2: Real-Time Policy Checks During Search

- Travel options are evaluated against company policy in real time
- Each option is clearly tagged as:
 - Within policy
 - Requires approval
 - Out of policy
- Structured exception capture with mandatory reason selection before submission

Addresses:

Late policy enforcement by preventing users from unknowingly selecting invalid options and by making approval requirements explicit upfront.

Solution 3: Secure Payments with Auto Invoice Generation

- Payment is unlocked only after approval
- Invoices are generated only upon successful payment

- Finance receives system-generated, traceable invoices

Addresses:

Finance reconciliation issues by ensuring end-to-end data integrity across booking, approval, and payment.

10. Minimum Viable Product (MVP)

MVP Objective

Reduce booking-to-approval time by eliminating uncertainty and rework—not by simply speeding up UI interactions.

MVP Scope

- Unified flight, hotel, and structured cab booking within a single travel request
- Real-time policy checks during search
- Secure payments with automatic invoice generations

11. Updated User Journey (Post-Platform)

1. Employee searches travel in a single platform
2. Sees policy status for each option upfront
3. Selects itinerary and submits request
4. System evaluates policy rules
 - a. If compliant → Auto-approved
 - b. If exception → Routed for contextual approval
5. Payment proceeds securely
6. Invoice is auto-generated and synced to finance

Outcome:

Uncertainty, rework, and finance follow-ups are significantly reduced.

12. Success Metrics

Primary Metrics

Booking-to-Approval Time

Measures average time from submission to approval (auto or manual), including exception handling.

First-Pass Approval Rate

Percentage of travel requests approved without requiring itinerary modifications or resubmission.

Payment Success Rate

Acts as a proxy for system reliability and user trust.

13. Go-To-Market Strategy

Target Customers

- Mid-to-large enterprises
 - Teams with frequent domestic travel
 - Approval-driven travel workflows
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Initial User Segments

- Existing enterprise customers
 - Sales, consulting, and operations teams with frequent travel
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Launch Strategy

- Pilot rollout with select teams
 - Admin-led onboarding for policies and approvers
 - Gradual employee rollout via booking flows
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